

JESTAZ YAO

Senior UX Researcher & Product Designer · Mixed-Methods Research · Design Systems & AI

"I design the system — the tokens, the components, and the decisions AI products make."

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Senior product designer with **5+ years** building enterprise-grade **design systems** and **AI products** end to end. I architect **3-tier tokenized design systems** — primitive → semantic → component, with **Figma Variables**, governed component libraries, and **Figma ↔ code parity via Code Connect** — and design the data-heavy **dashboards** and deterministic **AI decision workflows** that consume them (multi-agent orchestration, intent taxonomies, policy / confidence gating, structured outputs). Comfortable in code (TypeScript, Python, SwiftUI). Most recent: **Meridian**, a 288-token / 179-component enterprise design system consumed end-to-end by a working banking dashboard, with Figma and React kept in sync through Code Connect. I work research-first: pairing generative and evaluative studies — interviews, usability and A/B testing — with quantitative analysis, then turning synthesized, evidence-based insight into journeys, wireframes, and shipped product, with rigor built for high-accountability, public-facing products.

SELECTED PROJECTS

Meridian — Enterprise Design System & Treasury Dashboard

Jan 2026 – Mar 2026

Self-initiated reference system · jestazyao.com/projects/meridian

- Architected a **3-tier tokenized design system** — **288 Figma Variables** across Primitive, Semantic (Light/Dark modes), and Component tiers — published as a versioned **React library** (@jestaz/design-system) that a working Meridian Bank **treasury dashboard** consumes 100%, with zero one-off/local components.
- Authored **179 governed components** (variant sets, auto-layout, component properties, instance-swap icon library) and linked **Figma ↔ code with Code Connect**, so one design change resolves to the same token in both — and a single mode switch re-themes the entire product Light → Dark.
- Designed the data-heavy **treasury dashboard** end-to-end — KPI cards, cash-flow charts, balance breakdown, a sortable/filterable transactions table, a guided payments flow, and a 4-agent AI assistant — every screen pure composition over the library.
- Enforced governance & accessibility: **semantic versioning**, contribution workflow, a written design-system discipline standard, and **measured WCAG 2.1 AA** contrast (AAA on primary text), verified programmatically — paired with heuristic evaluation and task-based usability review of the dashboard before ship.

Bitez — On-Device AI iOS App · Live on the App Store

Apr 2026 – Jun 2026

Co-founder · apps.apple.com/us/app/bitez · jestazyao.com/projects/bitez

- Co-founded and shipped a **SwiftUI iOS app** to the US App Store using Apple's on-device Foundation Models to pick one restaurant — not fifty — and explain why in a friend's voice.
- Designed a **two-AI-moment architecture** that bounds the LLM narrowly: the model parses free-text input into structured intent and rewrites deterministic facts into a friend-voice line; recommendation logic runs in plain Swift, keeping the LLM out of every decision.
- Built a **hallucination guard** that rejects any AI output not anchored to a real fact (rating, distance, weather, preferences) — every reasoning row is sourced and user-auditable.
- Engineered **100% on-device privacy** (no backend, account, analytics, or tracking) with multi-pool caching driving ~80% API-call reduction.
- Drove the beta with **generative + evaluative research** — moderated usability sessions and tester interviews synthesized into a journey map (onboarding → mood-gate → pick), each build tied to a specific user observation; one such insight (a cheaper-than-budget pick read as "broken") became the most-praised feature.
- Result: live on the US App Store · 2 narrowly-scoped on-device AI integrations · 0 hallucinated narrations · zero backend.

Director — Supply Chain Decision System

Mar 2026 – Apr 2026

Independent · jestazyao.com/supplyai

- Designed a **multi-agent decision architecture** — four deterministic Python sub-agents coordinated by an LLM Director that selects which agents to run per query.
- Built and benchmarked **three router strategies** (regex, LLM tool-call, plan → reflect) through an evaluative research protocol — a 30-question test set scored on precision, recall and F1 (keyword 0.888 / LLM 0.792 / multi-step 0.831) — surfacing trade-offs while guarding against small-sample over-generalization and correlation/causation fallacies.
- Shipped **citation-drilling UX** (every finding expands to underlying data rows) and a plan → run → reflect agentic loop; built the product end-to-end (FastAPI, streaming SSE, live routing-graph visualization, CSV upload, Markdown/PDF export).
- Result: ~2s p50 latency · live demo, case study, and LinkedIn carousel shipped.

Demon Rising — Conversational AI System in a Shipped Game

Apr 2026 – May 2026

Independent · store.steampowered.com/app/4753210 · demonrising.jestazyao.com

- Designed a free-text negotiation system with a **5-way intent taxonomy** (agree/refuse/modify/counter/silence) mapping any open-ended input onto a bounded decision space.
- Architected a **fallback-first pipeline** (LLM classifier backed by a deterministic keyword classifier) with bounded-latency control ($\leq 8s$) so every interaction resolves even when the model is slow, offline, or malformed.
- Result: shipped on Steam & itch.io · 86% of players complete a full run (vs. 10–25% indie baseline) · 0 dead-end states · $\leq 8s$ worst-case latency.

The Translator Pattern — AI Support Automation System

Feb 2026 – Mar 2026

Independent · jestazyao.com/aipattern

- Designed a **4-gate decision pipeline** (intent → policy → confidence → clarification) that separates LLM reasoning from business rules and forces deterministic execution before any tool call.
- Built a structured intent taxonomy, a rule-based policy engine, confidence-threshold gating, multi-turn clarification, and JSON-schema output contracts for clean backend handoff.
- Result: 100% unauthorized-refund block rate · 6/6 adversarial tests passed · 0 hallucinated “refund processed” outputs.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Lead Product Designer (Contract) — Vetta Studio

Sep 2024 – Mar 2026

New York, NY

- Built a **tokenized, themeable design system** in Figma — design tokens and **Variables with light/dark + per-client brand modes**, plus a **governed component library** (variant sets, auto-layout, documentation) — reused across e-commerce, booking, and SaaS dashboard builds to standardize UI and cut design-to-dev handoff.
- **Atlas Concierge** (B2B travel SaaS): designed a **data-heavy conversational booking dashboard** — filters, status tables, real-time states, role-gated views — on **WCAG 2.1 AA** components with full keyboard and screen-reader support.
- **Mechapro** (high-ticket B2B e-commerce): designed product architecture, configurator UX, and decision flows from the shared component library — drove **\$38K+ revenue in 30 days** at \$9.7K average order value.
- **Beauty Affair**: shipped an AI-assisted booking experience generating 90+ bookings/month and ~\$5K projected monthly revenue.
- **Halo Wellness** (DTC skincare): designed an AI product-recommendation quiz and onboarding flow, then ran a hypothesis-driven A/B test with a pre-defined success metric that lifted email opt-in conversion.
- Stood up the studio's research practice across e-commerce, booking, and SaaS builds: defined research plans and hypotheses, recruited participants matching each client's target demographic and behavioral profile, ran mixed-methods studies (interviews + usability + analytics), and delivered synthesized, actionable insight decks to cross-disciplinary stakeholders (product, engineering, data).

Lead UI/UX Designer · Mobile App Instructor — Sage Test Prep

Aug 2025 – Jan 2026

New York, NY

- Led redesign and launch of two production websites with AI-driven discovery and Q&A flows; introduced journey mapping and structured usability review into the process and matured the team's research toolkit, mentoring designers on evidence-based UX.
- Built structured AI interaction patterns (intent capture, constraint handling, fallback escalation) and delivered **WCAG 2.1 AA**, multi-language, cross-platform (iOS/Android) experiences with screen-reader support, keyboard nav, and explicit focus states.

UI/UX Designer · Mobile & Design Systems — Appetizer Mobile

Oct 2021 – Mar 2023

New York, NY

- Established and scaled **tokenized design systems** — design tokens (color, type, spacing, elevation), **Figma component libraries** with auto-layout, variants, and documentation standards, and **light/dark theming** — across iOS/Android, admin panels, and **data dashboards**.
- Designed **admin panels and analytics dashboards** (data tables, charts, KPI surfaces, empty/error/loading states) and led 0 → 1 product design for AI surfaces and blockchain apps, built to **WCAG 2.1 AA** contrast and keyboard-navigation specs.
- **Bountify** (token-based flows): aligned wallet connectivity, rewards, and real-time system states with mobile UX to lift completion and retention.
- Drove team adoption of AI-assisted design tooling to accelerate execution while holding craft.

Lead UI/UX Designer (Web3) — Orbimatrix

Mar 2023 – Sep 2024

New York, NY

- Led UX for a Web3 trivia platform with on-chain rewards and wallet connectivity. Planned and moderated task-based usability testing with post-task interviews, triangulated the qualitative findings with engagement analytics, and shipped fixes that lifted engagement 15%; also migrated the team from Sketch to Figma mid-project.

E-commerce Designer — ReikoWireless

Jun 2021 – Oct 2021

New York, NY

- Wireframed and prototyped product pages and checkout flow in Figma to reduce abandonment and lift conversion; shipped responsive across desktop and mobile breakpoints.

SKILLS

Design Systems & Tokens

Design tokens (3-tier: primitive · semantic · component) · Token architecture & naming conventions · **Figma Variables & Modes** (light/dark · multi-brand theming) · Governed **component libraries** (variant sets · auto-layout · component properties) · Instance-swap icon systems · **Figma ↔ code parity (Code Connect)** · Design-system governance (semantic versioning · changelog · contribution workflow) · **Dashboard & data-visualization design** · Documentation standards · Accessibility-baked components (WCAG 2.1 AA) · Storybook (foundational)

AI Systems & LLM Design

Multi-agent orchestration · LLM Director / router patterns · Eval-driven design (F1 / precision / recall) · Plan → reflect agentic loops · Streaming SSE · Citation / grounding UX · Intent taxonomy · Structured JSON outputs · Deterministic policy engines · Confidence-threshold gating · Fallback / graceful-degradation design · Latency budgeting · On-device LLM (Apple Foundation Models) · Tool-calling orchestration · Multi-turn state · Prompt design & behavior control · Hallucination guards · RAG & embedding retrieval (foundational)

Product & UX Strategy

Generative research (field studies · interviews) · Evaluative research (usability testing · A/B testing) · Mixed-methods research · Research plans & hypotheses · Qualitative & quantitative analysis · Statistical analysis · Participant recruitment · Research synthesis & reporting · Research ops / toolkit · User journey mapping · Information architecture · User flow & interaction design · Wireframing & rapid prototyping · Heuristic evaluation · Cross-functional collaboration · Evidence-based product design · Accessibility (WCAG 2.1 AA · keyboard · screen-reader · contrast validation)

Tools

Figma · Figma Variables · Code Connect · Figma Make · Storybook (foundational) · Sketch · ProtoPie · Adobe Suite · Anthropic API (Claude) · OpenAI API · Apple Foundation Models · SwiftUI · Xcode · FastAPI · Python · TypeScript · JSON Schema · React · HTML/CSS · Bubble.io · Wix Studio · VS Code · Jira · Miro

Data & Growth

Google Analytics · Google Search Console · Google Ads · SQL · Excel

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Fine Arts (BFA) — Queens University

Jun 2016 – Jun 2020

Queens, NY

CERTIFICATIONS

LinkedIn Learning: UX Foundations (Usability Testing · Interaction Design) · Data Analytics for Business Professionals · UX Deep Dive: Remote Research. **FutureLearn:** Introduction to Creative AI · Introduction to Conversational Interfaces.